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RAMNATH GOENKA

◆ IN 1932 ◆

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Students need a safe home. That’s DU’s duty

THE SATYA NIKETAN tragedy has brought much-needed attention to accommodation for Delhi University (DU) students. The figures underline the scale of the problem: Around 70,000 students are enrolled in DU’s undergraduate programmes every year, and its PG courses have more than 10,000 seats. While the university’s hostels have 3,422 seats, the colleges affiliated to it have 3,788 seats. Many of these students come from outside the city, and it’s clear that DU’s hostel network cannot accommodate them. The result is a vast dependence on private paying-guest facilities and rented accommodation, often in densely packed neighbourhoods with unsafe conditions close to university campuses. For outstation students, the soaring accommodation costs offset DU’s affordable tuition fees. Seven months after assuming office, the university’s vice chancellor announced plans to build two 1,000-bed hostels near North Campus. But as an investigation in this paper shows, as the VC begins a second term next month, the projects remain held up by funding constraints, space crunch, land-use restrictions and administrative hurdles.

The immediate priority must be to expand safe and affordable hostel accommodation, while also recognising that the gap is too large to be bridged by construction projects initiated by the university alone. In the past, the Delhi government, DU and its colleges have rarely come together to devise solutions that treat student housing as part of the university’s essential infrastructure. Delhi’s master plans have allowed property owners to adapt their houses to provide student accommodation, provided they adhere to safety norms. In practice, these caveats were flouted. At the same time, DU hasn’t shown much initiative to engage with the private accommodation market around its campuses. Options such as a university-maintained database of accommodation, with information on rents, occupancy, and compliance with basic safety standards, were never explored.

After the Satya Niketan tragedy, Delhi’s Chief Minister has called for a survey to identify colleges with sufficient space for hostel construction. These units will be built via public-private partnership, and the Delhi CM has promised that the government will ensure students’ safety. These are steps in the right direction, but the government needs to do more. For starters, it needs to nudge the colleges to look at out-of-the-box solutions — drawing in entrepreneurs by pooling the colleges’ unused parcels of land into hostel sites could be an option. A student life in Delhi helps many youngsters spread their wings. As the brother of one of the victims of the Satya Niketan incident told this paper, “he loved the city”. The best tribute to those who lost their lives last week would be to end the lack of imagination and political will that denies people like them a safe home in the city.

A small fee, a stronger UPI

THE NATIONAL Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has announced that UPI transactions over Rs 2,000 will attract a fee of 0.4 per cent from October 15. Called the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR), the fee, capped at Rs 300 per transaction, applies only to person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions. The Union Ministry of Finance has stated that banks have been “advised” to ensure merchants — e-commerce websites, grocery shops or shopkeepers, receiving more than Rs 1 lakh per month from customers paying through UPI — do not pass on the cost to customers. It has also been clarified that for certain categories of transactions — such as UPI payments received for rail tickets, fuel and agricultural inputs, credit card dues, telecom or utility bills, insurance premiums, and tax payments — a flat merchant fee of Rs 5 will be charged from merchants. There are several reasons why this decision should be welcomed.

These changes follow the passage of the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Act, 2026 last month, which built on the recommendations of the 32nd report of the Standing Committee on Finance. The report had noted that “the absence of MDR makes the UPI ecosystem financially unsustainable”. The MDR is the fee paid to the bank or payment service provider for processing digital transactions, and crores of transactions take place each year. In 2025-26, for instance, there were more than 24,000 crore UPI transactions, and their total value was Rs 314 lakh crore. UPI was introduced in 2016 with an MDR. The zero-MDR policy was adopted in 2020 to expand the adoption of digital transactions. The balanced approach in the latest shift will ensure a sustainable revenue flow to invest, while also enabling seamless digital payments for a large section of people — this could lead to greater reach.

The decision has attracted some criticism. The main Opposition party, for instance, has claimed the move will hurt consumers, especially the poor ones. Such criticism is unfounded. More than 95 per cent of UPI transactions are below the Rs 2,000 threshold. These changes do not apply to person-to-person transactions, and critical public services will have a flat fee. There is an MDR on credit cards as well. Allowing these charges will ensure more competition in the marketplace and better service delivery.

A gambit for Gukesh, and for India

A DAY before India began its Chess Olympiad campaign in Samarkand, captain Srinath Narayanan played his biggest gambit: Gukesh D would play on board 4, the final board. It’s unprecedented for a reigning world champion to play on board 4. At the previous two Olympiads, Gukesh was on board 1, where he had delivered individual golds. The board order is more than a matter of prestige at the Olympiad: Board 1 is usually reserved for a country’s top players, which ensures they play the cream of other nations.

Does Narayanan’s choice indicate that the team management lacks faith in the 20-year-old after his slump since becoming the world champion? He has gone from being the World no. 5 in December 2024 with a rating of 2783 to currently being the World no. 31, rated 2703. In his last tournament, the Chennai Grandmasters, he did not win a single match. By his own admission, his Achilles’ heel is going for risky moves which, when a player is low on confidence, can backfire.

India not playing Gukesh on the top boards might actually work in the reigning world champion’s favour. Getting to face weaker players over 11 rounds at the Olympiad could be the best way for him to gain back confidence in time for his world crown defence. He can take risks, like his style demands, and not be made to pay by opponents — the equivalent of an Indian cricketer going back to play the Ranji Trophy to get some runs under his belt. It just might be a gambit that helps India retain the gold.



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

THE PARADOX of Indian civilisation has always been the contradiction between our intellectual radicalism and our social orthodoxy. For millennia, the Subcontinent was a laboratory of boundless metaphysical inquiry, where the foundational texts of the Indic tradition openly questioned the origins of the universe, and where heterodox sceptics, materialists, and spiritual iconoclasts debated without fear of a Spanish-style Inquisition. Hindus have no concept of heresy because we did not fear the destabilising power of an idea. Yet, in modern India, this heritage of intellectual fearlessness is being systematically stifled by the misuse of a legal relic that elevates the fragile feelings of the mob over the fundamental rights of the individual. This is Section 295A of the Indian Penal Code, now re-codified as Section 299 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

Introduced by the British in 1927 in the turbulence of the “Rangela Rasool” controversy (a provocative Urdu pamphlet satirising the Prophet Muhammad’s personal life had sparked widespread communal riots), Section 295A was ostensibly designed to preserve public order by penalising deliberate and malicious acts intended to outrage religious feelings. It was born out of a colonial urge to police Indian subjects deemed too volatile to handle the friction of free and provocative speech. The British

have abolished their own blasphemy law, but we not only retain this colonial instrument under Article 19(2) of our Constitution, which permits speech restrictions in the interests of public order, but have allowed it to metastasise into the single most potent weapon against creative and intellectual freedom in our democracy.

By translating the deeply subjective and volatile concept of “emotional hurt” into a cognisable, non-bailable criminal offence, Section 299 of the BNS effectively grants a permanent “heckler’s veto” to the most intolerant, reactionary segments of our society. It creates a perverse incentive for outrage by elevating “the right to be offended” above the right to free speech. Political entrepreneurs, religious zealots, and competitive vigilante groups quickly realise that the easiest path to public relevance is to claim that their sentiments have been wounded. All it takes is one aggrieved individual to file a First Information Report (FIR) in a remote corner of the country, and the machinery of the state is instantly triggered against a writer, a filmmaker, a stand-up comedian, or a publisher — for speech that a court will often find, years later, was never malicious at all.

The alarming phenomenon of cultural self-censorship in India is starkly illustrated by the corporate capitulation of major publishers, fearful of falling afoul of BNS 299. This trend was dramatically underscored when Penguin Books India chose to withdraw distribution of Joe Sacco’s graphic novel on the Muzaffargarh riots, echoing its earlier decision to pulp copies of Wendy Doniger’s *The Hindus*, and then anxiously asked for cuts to Sonia Gandhi’s memoirs that its global arm had not considered necessary in the international edition. Because none of these texts was legally proscribed, these were pre-emptive surrenders,

Those who weaponise BNS 299 to defend faith are, in reality, insulting the very traditions they claim to protect. The great Indic philosophies were forged through intense, unsparing contestation

Thorny inter-state disputes are giving way to dialogue, progress



HIMANTA BISWA SARMA

AS NARENDRA MODI completes 25 years as the head of a government — first as Chief Minister of Gujarat and for over a decade as Prime Minister of India — one conviction has remained constant. “India cannot advance without all its states advancing in tandem. States and the Centre must work together to forge a model of cooperative federalism, resolve differences, and chart a common course to progress and prosperity.” PM Modi said this at the first meeting of the NITI Aayog Governing Council in February 2015. It is a vision he has carried since his days as Gujarat CM, and one he has entrusted, as PM, to Union Home Minister Amit Shah to translate into reality. Over the last few months, the Union Home Ministry has formalised memoranda of understanding that resolve some of India’s oldest inter-state disputes.

The first was the tripartite MoU between the Centre, my state of Assam, and Nagaland, signed on June 11. The second, among Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Haryana, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Delhi, revived the long-stalled Kishau Multipurpose Dam Project after an eight-year deadlock. The third, between Rajasthan and Haryana, ended a 32-year wait to operationalise the 1994 Upper Yamuna Basin agreement. The fourth, among Maharashtra, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan, was a one-time settlement of decades-pending dues under the Narmada Award. Most recently, Bihar and Jharkhand signed a pact ending a 25-year dispute over the Sone River. Within the same framework, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana have agreed to finally resolve their pending division of assets and liabilities.

As Gujarat’s longest-serving chief minister, most of it under a Congress-led Union government, he saw firsthand how inter-state and Centre-state disagreements can stall welfare works and become the genesis of societal disturbance. These agreements, touching some 15 states, are, I believe, part of the biggest rejuvenation of India’s federal structure.

A case in point is the Assam, Nagaland

and Union government tripartite MoU. This agreement had eluded three governments for three decades. At stake was a belt of more than 1,000 square km straddling the Assam-Nagaland border, where domestic oil exploration had been effectively frozen because of a poorly demarcated, ambiguous boundary finalised in 1963. Committed to the PM’s agenda of an *atmanirbhar* Bharat, Amit Shah ji reframed the issue. Under his guidance, Assam and Nagaland agreed on a 50:50 split of hydrocarbon revenue, irrespective of how the ongoing boundary resolution efforts conclude.

This is not an isolated agreement: The Bodo Peace Accord, the Karbi Anglong settlement, the Assam-Meghalaya boundary agreement, the Assam-Arunachal Pradesh border resolution, and the Frontier Nagaland arrangement addressing the decades-old Eastern Naga demand for separate administrative recognition. This rapid succession of peace accords and MoUs in the Northeast is finally yielding dividends in building a secure *Ashtalakshmi* — a region once familiar with insurgency is now 80 per cent free of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act.

These agreements are a reminder of what steady, patient leadership can achieve. Disputes that outlasted governments of every hue, that were allowed to fester because resolving them seemed politically inconvenient, are today being settled not through grand gestures but through the unglamorous, persistent work of dialogue.

This is the hallmark of PM Modi’s leadership: A refusal to accept that any problem is too old or too complicated to be solved, and an unwavering belief that a strong, united India is built by strengthening its states, not by centralising at their expense. As the nation looks ahead to the goal of a *Viksit Bharat* by 2047, it does so with the confidence that comes from 25 years of proof that when the Centre and the states work as one, even the most stubborn of disputes give way to progress. That is the true and lasting message of the Modi story.

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normalising a cowardly calculus where commercial risk aversion replaces constitutional principle, leaving the Indian reader culturally deprived.

The tragedy of BNS 299 lies in the grueling, punitive nature of the legal process itself. The law allows arrest before a trial can even establish whether malice existed. For an artist or an author, being dragged through a labyrinth of multi-city court appearances, facing jail time and enduring financial ruin, is a punishment designed to break the spirit. The inevitable consequence is a pervasive, suffocating culture of fear. When the cost of creative expression is the potential loss of personal liberty, the vast majority of creators naturally choose to pull their punches. Publishers refuse or trim sensitive manuscripts, galleries pull provocative paintings, studios quietly cancel scripts, and academics choose safer, sterile research topics. We are left with a public square sanitised of radical honesty, reduced to a bland conformity that is entirely unworthy of India’s intellectual lineage.

In his landmark 2008 Delhi High Court judgment quashing criminal proceedings against the self-exiled maestro M F Husain, Justice Sanjay Kishan Kaul delivered a magnificent, definitive defence of artistic liberty against the creeping tides of intolerance. Opening the ruling with a quote from Pablo Picasso (“Art is never chaste... Where it is chaste, it is not art”), Justice Kaul meticulously dismantled the obscenity and blasphemy charges by contextualising Husain’s abstract, nude depiction of Bharat Mata within India’s rich, four-millennia-old heritage of sacred, pluralistic, and erotic iconography, from Khajuraho to Konark. Sternly critiquing the “new puritanism” being waged by self-appointed guardians of cultural purity, the judgment warned that

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Real test for BRICS: Offer a credible alternative



AFTAB ALAM

DEAR EDITOR I disagree

A fortnightly column in which we invite readers to tell us why, when they differ with the editorial positions or news coverage of ‘The Indian Express’

The New Delhi Declaration is clear about the shortcomings of the existing order but offers little indication of how these problems can be addressed

TWO RECENT editorials — ‘At BRICS, the value of keeping difficult conversations alive’ (*IE*, September 12) and ‘At BRICS, more options, a win for diplomacy’ (*IE*, September 14) — make a persuasive case for BRICS as a useful forum for dialogue and diplomacy. But they set too low a bar for judging the grouping at a time when the international order is undergoing profound change.

At the heart of their argument is the idea that, despite its internal differences and competing interests, BRICS remains a useful instrument of diplomacy in a fragmented world. Its expanded membership strengthens the Global South’s voice and creates greater scope for economic cooperation. It also brings together countries with competing interests, making BRICS a useful forum for keeping diplomatic channels open on difficult geopolitical questions while making conscious efforts to avoid being seen as an explicitly anti-Western or anti-American alignment.

But this optimism should not obscure the harder realities of international politics. States use multilateral forums to advance their interests, manage vulnerabilities and respond to shifts in power. What matters is whether dialogue can help resolve disputes, moderate conflicts, produce meaningful cooperation and contribute to a more stable, rules-based international order. John Mearsheimer argues that international institutions do not transcend power politics; they largely reflect the distribution of power and the interests of the states that use them. BRICS may be less an independent force shaping international politics than a forum through which states respond to changing configurations of power and pursue converging interests.

The bonhomie between Narendra Modi and Xi Jinping, following years of border tensions and Xi’s first visit to India since 2019, should not be seen simply as a triumph of BRICS diplomacy. India and China have strategic reasons to reduce tensions amid Donald Trump’s attempt to weaponise tariffs. The rapprochement may give both greater room for manoeuvre in dealing with the US, without requiring either to appear confrontational.

The larger question is what BRICS seeks to achieve beyond providing its members with a forum for dialogue and diplomatic options. The New Delhi Declaration is clear about the shortcomings of the existing order — unilateral sanctions, coercive measures, protectionism, tariffs and the unequal representation of developing countries in global institutions — but offers little indication of how these can be addressed. Even its call for reform of global institutions leaves unanswered the question of how such reform can be achieved. As G John Ikenberry suggests, the present moment may be less about the collapse of the US-led liberal international order than a struggle over its future shape, authority and leadership. BRICS has yet to articulate what that future might look like politically, economically and institutionally.

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40 YEARS AGO September 17, 1986



BSF to continue combing

THE CENTRE has directed the BSF to continue its operations against intruders from Pakistan and to shoot them if they do not respond when challenged. The fresh directions were issued to remove doubts about the role of the BSF guarding the India-Pakistan border in Punjab following the killing of 10 Sikh youths who intruded in the Dera Baba Nanak sector of Gurdaspur district on August 30. The youths “failed” to make their intentions clear when a BSF patrol challenged them.

Shiv Sena leader, Nihang shot

TERRORISTS IN Punjab, after lying low for

a brief period, struck again, killing two persons, including a Hindu Shiv Sena leader, and injuring at least five others in separate incidents. Vijay Mohan, vice-chairman of the Phillaur unit of the Shiv Sena, was fatally wounded by scooter-borne terrorists in the morning. A call for a bandh in Phillaur has been given by the Punjab Shiv Sena president, Rama Kant Jalota, to protest against the killing.

Horror in Bombay’s KEM

HIGHLY DECOMPOSED flesh and bones were fished out of a potable water tank of the King Edward Memorial (KEM) Hospital in Bombay. Hospital employees said that it was difficult to say whether the flesh was

of an animal or a human baby. The police said that *prima facie* it looked like animal flesh, but added that expert opinion was awaited. The flesh and bones have been sent to the police surgeon for analysis.

Army to help control floods

TROOPS WERE called out in Pharenda and Maharajganj tehsils of Gorakhpur district in Uttar Pradesh and east and west Champaran districts of Bihar, to help the civil authorities control the worsening flood situation. According to reports received in New Delhi, scores of villages were submerged by floodwaters even as the flood situation in other parts of Uttar Pradesh showed considerable improvement.